Tennessee and Me

By Will Scheffer

ME speaks with a heavy New York accent. Tennessee speaks with a very broad deep Southern drawl.

ME: On February 25th, 1983, at approximately 2:00 in the morning, while taking a hot bath in his suite at the Hotel Elysee, the great playwright and notoriously alcoholic homosexual, Tennessee Williams, died amidst the bubbles, asphyxiated by the cap of a pill vial, lodged in his throat.

INTRODUCTION

"For nowadays the world is lit by lightning, so blow out your candles . . . " This line closes out one of Tennessee Williams most famous plays, The Glass Menagerie . . . . They are uttered by Laura's brother, Tom. When Tom talks of the world being "lit by lightning," what he means is that he has made the plunge - he has left the quiet sadness of a world lit by his sister's candles and traded it for the unceasing excitement of a lightning storm as a member of the merchant marines. He asks Laura to blow out her candles - in effect, for her memory to stop haunting him - because he no longer sees the world by the dull light of candles. Instead, his world is lit by the excitement of lightning. As much as it pains him to do it, he needs to leave her behind and embrace the decision he has made to live in the heart of lightning.

It is this line that forms the basis of this dramatic interp. In it you will meet a street-wise male prostitute known only as "ME" who is struggling with his sexuality. It is through his interaction with the confident gay spirit of Tennessee Williams that he comes to realize that, rather than being a frightening place of uncertainty . . . the world truly is "lit by lightning." ME must leave the past behind to embrace and accept his sexual identity and the future that is to come.

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Lighting candles as he speaks

ME: It so happens that on that same unfortunate morning about an hour earlier, I - who at that time was a rather inarticulate male prostitute from

Bensonhurst, Brooklyn - was running naked through the lobby of the Holiday Inn on 48th street, having just extinguished a cigarette in the sagging white belly of a Pulitzer Prize-winning poet, who had paid me five hundred dollars to do so, but who now seemed to be suffering from mild cardiac arrest apparently brought on by my action.

Grasping my five hundred dollars, I ran from the hotel and lunged into a waiting taxi and throwing a one hundred dollar bill into the front seat ordered the gaping cabby to take me to the St. Marks Baths, a popular gay bathhouse on the lower east side that flourished in the innocent age before the plague had come to live with us in this city of strangers.

Upon checking into the baths that night I procured for myself the honeymoon suite. The only room in the entire place with a double bed, and at precisely 2:00 A.M., exactly as uptown Mr. Williams was choking in his tub, [I] staggered to the mirror and stared in shock and horror at what I saw reflected there, for the eyes that stared back at me were not my own, and I knew somehow quite clearly, that in one shining instant, oblivious as to how and why he had chosen me, the soul of Tennessee Williams had leapt into my body like a candle flame leaping into the dark night; I was possessed.

ME: What are you doing?

TENNESSEE: I'm moving in baby.

ME: You can't move in. Get out of me!

TENNESSEE: But honey - we've had this date with each other from the beginning.

ME: Why do you have to move into me?

TENNESSEE: I've come back for love, baby . . . and you have the body to get it

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for me.

ME: I don't even know who you are!

TENNESSEE: Jus' hush up then . . . I've always depended on the kindness of strangers.

ME: *(to audience)* This was indeed a predicament of major proportions for me, as I had practiced a lifetime avoiding such flagrant effeminacy. And so fleeing from the baths, I instinctively searched for the nearest Catholic Church, believing exorcism to be my only hope.

When I entered the Church of the Heavenly Mother on Third Street it was empty, save for a rather young and attractive priest who was wearing a simple black habit and swinging a smoking incense burner over the altar. I ran to him, genuflecting at his feet. I was about to explain my unfortunate situation when Tennessee who was putting up a tremendous fight to inhabit me, lurched into high gear. And again unable to control myself, while looking the priest up and down, I intoned: "DAHUNG, I love your dress but your bag's on fire." Expecting the priest to take grave offense I cringed before him. But I was surprised when I heard him let out a fluttering shriek of a laugh. And soon it was quite clear to me that this Tennessee Williams was planning to move in for good. I began to speak with a southern accent even as I despised his presence inside me. *(Southern accent creeps in.)*

He dragged me to bar after bar in search of love, to all the bars I had frequented before to earn my living. Sometimes he would have me affect my most unavailable demeanor, and on those nights we were remarkably successful at winning the favors of boys of all different colors shapes and sizes.

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TENNESSEE: The only thing that homosexuals hate more than women is themselves!

ME: *(To audience)* But it really didn't matter. Any way we played it, the elusive love that Tennessee had come back for, continued to elude us. I however became used to having Tennessee in my body. We had a strange sort of marriage, and for the first time in my life I experienced a more delicate sensibility. I became morose, I began to think about the sadness of the world. I bought a typewriter and started to write bad plays which Tennessee criticized unmercifully.

Then one night the impossible happened. We both fell in love with the same boy. A bright particular boy. Tennessee made me kiss him . . . right on the mouth. Something I had never done before, not even for money - because I guess I knew that it would make me a *real* homosexual. And the boy kissed back with sincerity. And I found that I liked it.

The object of our mutual infatuation was Freddy, who was in all ways a delight to behold, both in appearance and personality. I suppose Freddy was a notoriously modern homosexual. You know the kind: full of himself, unashamed, in your face . . . beautiful. He seemed actually to contain a wholeness of qualities that might best be described as a self. And the tragedy was: that Freddy really did love us. And I came to understand that this love was unacceptable to Tennessee and me. It was not long after that, while taking a bath, that Tennessee told me he was departing.

TENNESSEE: It's all loss here honey, and I could never bear it. Never then and never now, but thank you for the ride.

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ME: Please don't leave me Tenn. I'm just street trash without you.

TENNESSEE. No you're not baby, you just need to take hold of yourself - and gently, gently with love, hand your life back to yourself.

ME: *(to audience as he begins to blow out candles around the acting area. One at a time.)* And then he was gone - flying up, up in his bathtub, and into the night. Now I live alone. But there is something of Tennessee that remains with me still. A longing, a nostalgia for a time that will never be again. I might even go so far as to say that I miss those old days. Perhaps I am walking on the streets of this city, and I pass the old location of a bar or a nightclub that we used to frequent. Or perhaps I hear a familiar strain of music, a Donna Summers song, and the memories of that time rush back upon me, like the crystalline lights of a mirrored disco ball, like a thousand pieces of broken glass - Oh Tennessee I tried to forget you. But it's been harder than I ever thought it would be. For nowadays the world is lit by lightning, so blow out your candles, Tennessee. And so good-bye. *(blows out the last candle)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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